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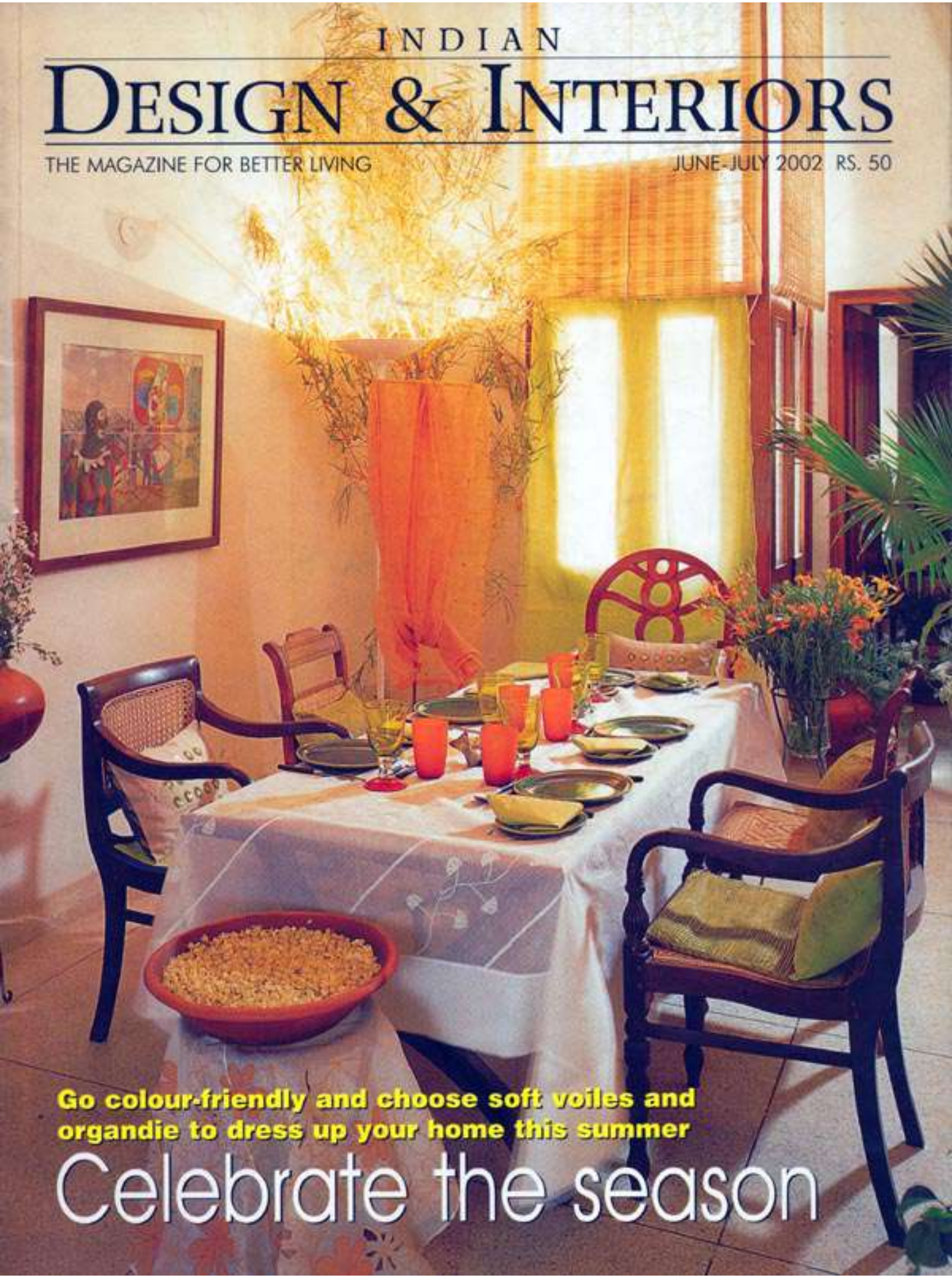


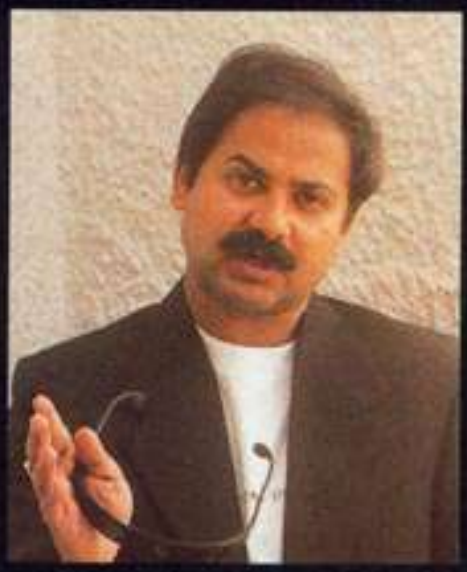
Go colour-friendly and choose soft voiles and organdie to dress up your home this summer

Celebrate the season

Product designer ◆ Vibhor Sogani

Drama in the

line



Facing page: Regiment, a multi-bud vase
Left: Vibhor Sogani
Above: Egg-holders in steel

The artist has transformed steel—for long relegated to kitchen utensils—to make dramatic design statements, writes **Amit Gupta**

A graduate from the National Institute of Design (NID), Vibhor Sogani has worked on numerous industrial and product design assignments for multinationals and corporates. With the experience of more than nine years behind him, Sogani has put together a collection which is shortly going to be on sale in select outlets in New Delhi, Mumbai and Bangalore.

While specialising in space design and industrial product design in 1992-93 in NID, Sogani worked on live projects with companies like Brite Plastics, Bluestar and Bajaj Tempo. After graduating, he started as an industrial designer with Godrej, working on a premium furniture line, which was launched after a few years. He left Godrej to start O.D.D, an acronym for Office of Design and Development with industrial design projects from Usha Shriram. Simultaneously, he developed a range of home accessories for the kitchen and dining as well as barbecue and garden tools for TAG-USA.

Sogani also developed the first four go-carting tracks in the country, designing all the constituent components, promotional and interactive installations for the tracks.

Over the last year-and-a-half, Sogani has been exclusively working on his own brand, Stylus Worldwide. He has developed a collection of lifestyle accessories, rich in form and bold in material usage, adding to the pleasure of living.

"Design concepts involve a line of thought, which then gets translated into forms. Finally, comes the choice of material and the execution," he says of his products.

The collection, Anarchy, is a no-frills concept. It comprises soft, clean lines and minimalist steel

curves. "These products emerge from a relationship of high gloss, fluid stainless steel coupled with bold, stark wood. They need space to be appreciated," he says.

The Coronation fruit platter, for instance, rests on a straight, well-finished wooden base. On a large dining table it has the potential of lifting the environment and adding that extra bit of confidence to the room. A multi-bud vase, Regiment, with its bold, steel curves, forms an arc on a solid wooden base and adds colour to the environment.

Fleet, in stainless steel and wood, is a novel idea for floating candles/fragrant flowers. The Sovereign vase, that makes room for an elegant spray of flowers, acts as the perfect foil to Fleet.

It's amazing how over the course of one and a half century, pewter gave way to other metals like brass, nickel silver, aluminum and then stainless steel, whose cycle of development is still running its course. Sogani and his generation of designers, from the world over, have started a new trend with an age-old material. From salt and pepper shakers called Consort to Dynasty coasters, Estate trivets and Dignity toothpick holders, these products have transformed steel, which was earlier seen as a utilitarian metal. Now, it makes dramatic design statements.

Above: Dynasty coasters
Below: Shield card holder

The Cherish photo frames and the Shield card holder, which keeps visiting cards in one place, have a modern definition of design.

Sogani's collection has subtle yet magical dimensions to which the viewer is drawn subconsciously. Besides Anarchy, Sogani will be showcasing more than seven lines of well-coordinated lifestyle statements in India and abroad. How a small pebble can get translated in a range of products, or how a basic clip can be played around to develop into a series of product is what Sogani's forthcoming launches will show.

(Vibhor Sogani's collection is available at select stores as part of the vis-à-vis:Alessi collection.)

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